



Incident handler's journal

Instructions

As you continue through this course, you may use this template to record your findings after completing an activity or to take notes on what you've learned about a specific tool or concept. You can also use this journal as a way to log the key takeaways about the different cybersecurity tools or concepts you encounter in this course.

Date: 10/30/2025	Entry: #1
Description	Documenting a cybersecurity incident
Tool(s) used	Not used
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. ● Who: An organized group of unethical hackers ● What: A ransomware security incident ● Where: At a health care company ● When: Tuesday at 9am ● Why: The incident originated from a phishing email containing a malicious attachment, which, once opened, triggered ransomware deployment. The attack encrypted critical system files and was accompanied by a ransom note from an organized threat actor demanding payment for the decryption key.
Additional notes	The company appears to lack adequate employee training on phishing awareness, and there is no evidence of essential security controls such as IDS/IPS, antivirus solutions, or properly configured firewalls. The absence of a backup strategy further exposes the organization to unnecessary risk. Paying attackers for a decryption key is strongly discouraged, as it does not

	guarantee data recovery and may create additional legal and security complications.
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Date: 11/17/2025	Entry: #2
Description	Investigating an alert about a suspicious file
Tool(s) used	IDS
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. ● Who Organized group APT of unethical hackers ● What A malware security incident ● When Monday at 1:11pm ● Where Financial service company ● Why An employee received an email containing an attachment. The attachment was a password-protected spreadsheet file. The spreadsheet's password was provided in the email. The employee downloaded the file, then entered the password to open the file. When the employee opened the file, a malicious payload was then executed on their computer.
Additional notes	Training must be provided for employees on social engineering.

Date: 11/21/25 Record the date of the journal entry.	Entry: #3 Record the journal entry number.
Description	Investigating an alert about a suspicious file.
Tool(s) used	IDS
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. ● Who An email was sent by someone identifying as Clyde West from Def Communications ● What A phishing email was sent to hr@inergy.com with a subject line referencing a job application ● When Wednesday, July 20, 2022, at 09:30:14 AM ● Where The incident occurred within the Inergy corporate email system, specifically targeting the HR department ● Why The attacker likely aimed to: Trick HR personnel into opening a malicious executable under the guise of a job application; Exploit curiosity or urgency in hiring processes; Bypass antivirus detection by using a password-protected file.
Additional notes	Training must be provided for employees on social engineering.

Date: 11/26/2025	Entry: #4
Description	Unauthorized access to customer PII and financial data via web application vulnerability.

Tool(s) used	Web server access logs, vulnerability scanner, forced browsing detection tools.
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. ● Who An external attacker exploiting a web application vulnerability. ● What The attacker accessed approximately 50,000 customer records by manipulating order numbers in purchase confirmation URLs. ● When 12/22/2022 at 3:13pm ● Where E-commerce web application backend and customer-facing confirmation pages. ● Why A lack of access control allowed forced browsing of sequential order confirmation pages.
Additional notes	Recommendations include routine vulnerability scans, allowlisting URL access, and enforcing authenticated access to sensitive content.

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Description	Provide a brief description about the journal entry.
Tool(s) used	List any cybersecurity tools that were used.
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. ● Who caused the incident? ● What happened?

	● When did the incident occur? ● Where did the incident happen? ● Why did the incident happen?
Additional notes	Include any additional thoughts, questions, or findings.

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Additional notes	Include any additional thoughts, questions, or findings.

Need another journal entry template?

If you want to add more journal entries, please copy one of the tables above and paste it into the template to use for future entries.

Reflections/Notes: Record additional notes.